NATIONAL BUILDERS CORP

PROJECT PLANNING GUIDE

"From Idea to Impact"

Complete 20-Page Simple Planning Tool | Ages 7-17 | 2025 Edition

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INTRODUCTION: WHY PLANNING MATTERS

Welcome to Project Planning!

Many people have great ideas but poor execution. Why? Because they skip planning.

The difference between:

- A dream and a goal = A written plan
- An idea and a project = An action plan
- Hope and results = Measurement plan

"Failing to plan is planning to fail."

This workbook will guide you step-by-step to create a solid project plan. Don't rush through it. Take your time. A good plan saves you months of wasted effort.

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

1. **Read each section carefully**
2. **Answer every question honestly**
3. **Discuss your answers with your team/mentor**
4. **Revise your plan as you learn more**
5. **Keep this workbook handy** - refer to it throughout your project

WHAT MAKES A GOOD PROJECT PLAN?

A good plan is:

- ✅**SPECIFIC** - Clear details, not vague ideas
- ✅**REALISTIC** - You can actually do it with available resources
- ✅**MEASURABLE** - You can prove your impact with numbers
- ✅**TIME-BOUND** - Has deadlines and milestones
- ✅**FLEXIBLE** - Can adapt when things change

Let's begin planning your nation-building project!

STEP 1: UNDERSTAND THE PROBLEM

WHY THIS MATTERS

You can't solve a problem you don't understand. Many projects fail because they address symptoms, not root causes.

Example:

- **SYMPTOM:** Children are failing exams
- **ROOT CAUSE:** They can't read well (poor literacy in early grades)

If you only focus on exam prep, you won't solve the real problem. You must dig deeper.

1.1 DESCRIBE THE PROBLEM

What problem are you solving?

Write it in ONE simple sentence:

_____

_____

Good examples:

- "Children in my community don't have clean water to drink"
- "Youth in my area have no job skills and are unemployed"
- "Our school has no library, so students can't practice reading"

Bad examples (too vague):

- "Education is bad" (What exactly is bad about it?)
- "The community needs help" (What kind of help?)
- "Things are not working" (What things?)

1.2 WHERE IS THIS PROBLEM?

Be specific about location.

State: _____

LGA: _____

Community/Town: _____

Specific Location: _____

(Example: Beside the market, Near the mosque, At XYZ Primary School)

1.3 WHO HAS THIS PROBLEM?

Describe the people affected:

Who are they? (Age, gender, occupation, etc.)

_____

_____

How many people approximately?

☐ 10-50 people

☐ 50-100 people

☐ 100-500 people

☐ 500-1000 people

☐ More than 1000 people

Why does it matter to them? (How does this problem affect their daily lives?)

_____

_____

_____

_____

1.4 WHEN DID THIS PROBLEM START?

Understanding the history helps you understand the cause.

When did this problem begin?

_____

Is it getting worse, staying the same, or improving?

☐ Getting worse

☐ Staying the same

☐ Slightly improving (but still a problem)

Why?

_____

_____

1.5 WHY DOES THIS PROBLEM EXIST?

List at least 3 root causes:

Cause 1: _____

Cause 2: _____

Cause 3: _____

Example:

Problem: Children drink dirty water

Root Causes:

1. No clean water source nearby
2. Community can't afford to build a borehole
3. Government promised but never delivered

1.6 HAS ANYONE TRIED TO SOLVE THIS BEFORE?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Don't know

If YES, what did they try?

_____

_____

What happened? Why did it succeed or fail?

_____

_____

_____

What can you learn from their experience?

_____

_____

1.7 GATHER EVIDENCE

Don't just assume. Collect real data.

I will gather evidence by: *(Check all that apply)*

☐ Interviewing community members (at least 10 people)

☐ Taking photos/videos of the problem

☐ Counting/measuring the problem (numbers)

☐ Asking community leaders

☐ Reviewing any existing data (school records, health reports, etc.)

☐ Personal observation over several days

List 5 people you will interview:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Key questions to ask them:

1. How does this problem affect you?
2. What do you think causes this problem?
3. What have you tried to do about it?
4. What would help solve this problem?
5. What resources do we have locally that could help?

1.8 PROBLEM STATEMENT (Final Version)

Now that you've researched, write a clear problem statement:

TEMPLATE:

"[Number] of [who] in [location] suffer from [problem] because [root cause]. This matters because [impact on their lives]."

YOUR PROBLEM STATEMENT:

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Example:

"Over 500 primary school children in Mushin community lack access to books because our school has no library. This matters because children cannot practice reading at home, leading to poor literacy and exam failures."

STEP 2: DESIGN YOUR SOLUTION

WHY THIS MATTERS

Now that you understand the problem deeply, it's time to design your solution. A good solution:

- Addresses the ROOT CAUSE, not just symptoms
- Is realistic (you can actually do it)
- Fits the local context (works for this specific community)
- Uses available resources creatively

2.1 BRAINSTORM POSSIBLE SOLUTIONS

Don't judge ideas yet. Just brainstorm. List at least 5 different ways you could address this problem:

Possible Solution 1:

_____

_____

Possible Solution 2:

_____

_____

Possible Solution 3:

_____

_____

Possible Solution 4:

_____

_____

Possible Solution 5:

_____

_____

2.2 EVALUATE YOUR OPTIONS

For each solution above, rate it:

Solution	Can we do it? (1-5)	Will it work? (1-5)	Is it sustainable? (1-5)	TOTAL
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				

(1 = Very unlikely, 5 = Very likely)

The solution with the highest total score is your best option.

2.3 CHOOSE YOUR SOLUTION

I will implement this solution:

_____

_____

_____

_____

Why did you choose this one?

_____

_____

_____

2.4 HOW WILL YOUR SOLUTION WORK?

Describe in detail what you will actually DO:

Step-by-step description:

Step 1:

_____

_____

Step 2:

_____

_____

Step 3:

_____

_____

Step 4:

_____

_____

Step 5:

_____

_____

(Add more steps as needed)

2.5 WHY WILL THIS SOLUTION WORK?

Explain the logic behind your solution:

This solution will work because:

_____

_____

_____

_____

Evidence that supports this approach:

_____

_____

_____

2.6 WHAT COULD GO WRONG?

Think ahead about potential problems:

Risk 1:

_____

How I'll prevent/handle it:

_____

_____

Risk 2:

_____

How I'll prevent/handle it:

_____

_____

Risk 3:

_____

How I'll prevent/handle it:

_____

_____

2.7 HAVE OTHERS DONE SOMETHING SIMILAR?

Research similar projects:

Project/Organization: _____

What they did: _____

_____

What I can learn from them:

_____

_____

How my approach will be different/better:

_____

_____

STEP 3: CREATE YOUR ACTION PLAN

WHY THIS MATTERS

Ideas don't become reality without action. This section breaks your project into manageable tasks with deadlines.

3.1 PROJECT TIMELINE

Project Start Date: _____

Project End Date: _____

Total Duration: _____

(National Builders projects run May-October = 6 months)

3.2 MAJOR MILESTONES

Break your project into 4-6 major phases:

Milestone 1: _____

Target Date: _____

What must be complete: _____

_____

Milestone 2: _____

Target Date: _____

What must be complete: _____

_____

Milestone 3: _____

Target Date: _____

What must be complete: _____

_____

Milestone 4: _____

Target Date: _____

What must be complete: _____

_____

(Add more milestones as needed)

3.3 MONTHLY BREAKDOWN

MONTH 1 (May):

Main Activities:

_____

_____

_____

Who's Responsible:

_____

Deliverables (what you'll complete):

_____

_____

MONTH 2 (June):

Main Activities:

_____

_____

_____

Who's Responsible:

_____

Deliverables:

_____

_____

MONTH 3 (July):

Main Activities:

_____

_____

_____

Who's Responsible:

_____

Deliverables:

_____

_____

MONTH 4 (August):

Main Activities:

_____

_____

_____

Who's Responsible:

_____

Deliverables:

_____

_____

MONTH 5 (September):

Main Activities:

_____

_____

_____

Who's Responsible:

_____

Deliverables:

_____

_____

MONTH 6 (October):

Main Activities:

_____

_____

_____

Who's Responsible:

_____

Deliverables:

_____

_____

3.4 WEEKLY SCHEDULE

What day(s) each week will you work on your project?

☐ Monday

☐ Tuesday

☐ Wednesday

☐ Thursday

☐ Friday

☐ Saturday

☐ Sunday

What time?

_____

For how long?

_____

Where?

_____

3.5 TEAM ROLES & RESPONSIBILITIES

If you're working with a team, clarify who does what:

Team Member 1: _____

Role/Responsibilities:

_____

_____

Team Member 2: _____

Role/Responsibilities:

_____

_____

Team Member 3: _____

Role/Responsibilities:

_____

_____

Team Member 4: _____

Role/Responsibilities:

_____

_____

Team Member 5: _____

Role/Responsibilities:

_____

_____

How often will your team meet?

☐ Daily

☐ Weekly

☐ Bi-weekly

☐ Monthly

Meeting Day/Time: _____

Meeting Location: _____

STEP 4: MAP YOUR RESOURCES

WHY THIS MATTERS

National Builders projects require RESOURCEFULNESS, not big budgets. You'll be surprised how much you can accomplish with creativity and hustle.

4.1 MATERIALS NEEDED

List everything you need:

| Item | Quantity | Where to Get It | Estimated Cost |

|------|----------|----------------|----------------|

| | | | |

| | | | |

| | | | |

| | | | |

| | | | |

| | | | |

| | | | |

| | | | |

| | | | |

TOTAL ESTIMATED COST: ₦_____

4.2 HOW WILL YOU GET MATERIALS?

For each major item, identify how you'll obtain it:

☐ **BUY** (with what money?)

Source of funds:

_____

_____

☐ **BORROW** (from whom?)

_____

_____

☐ **DONATIONS** (who might donate?)

Potential donors to approach:

1. _____

2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

☐ **MAKE/BUILD** (from local materials)

What materials are available locally for free/cheap?

_____

_____

_____

☐ **IN-KIND CONTRIBUTIONS** (people donate services instead of money)

What services might people volunteer?

_____

_____

_____

4.3 PEOPLE WHO WILL HELP

Volunteers:

List people who will volunteer their time:

Name: _____

Skills: _____

How they'll help: _____

Name: _____

Skills: _____

How they'll help: _____

Name: _____

Skills: _____

How they'll help: _____

Experts/Advisors:

Who has expertise you need?

Name: _____

Expertise: _____

When you'll consult them: _____

Name: _____

Expertise: _____

When you'll consult them: _____

4.4 SKILLS YOU NEED TO LEARN

Be honest: What skills do you lack that your project requires?

Skill 1: _____

How I'll learn it:

_____

_____

Skill 2: _____

How I'll learn it:

_____

_____

Skill 3: _____

How I'll learn it:

_____

_____

4.5 PARTNERSHIPS

Could you partner with any organizations?

Potential Partner 1: _____

What they could provide:

_____

_____

How you'll approach them:

_____

_____

Potential Partner 2: _____

What they could provide:

_____

_____

How you'll approach them:

_____

_____

STEP 5: PLAN FOR IMPACT MEASUREMENT

WHY THIS MATTERS

You need to PROVE your project made a difference. Numbers and stories are your evidence.

5.1 WHAT WILL YOU MEASURE?

Choose 3-5 key metrics:

Metric 1: _____

How you'll count it:

_____

Target number:

_____

Metric 2: _____

How you'll count it:

_____

Target number:

_____

Metric 3: _____

How you'll count it:

_____

Target number:

_____

Metric 4: _____

How you'll count it:

_____

Target number:

_____

Metric 5: _____

How you'll count it:

_____

Target number:

_____

Example:

Metric: Number of children reading improved

How to count: Pre-test and post-test reading scores

Target: 80% of children improve by at least one grade level

5.2 BEFORE & AFTER

BEFORE (Baseline):

What does the situation look like NOW before your project starts?

Take measurements/photos in May:

_____

_____

_____

Photos to take:

☐ Current state of the problem

☐ The location/area

☐ People affected

AFTER (End-line):

What will you measure in October to show change?

_____

_____

_____

Photos to take:

☐ The solution in action

☐ Changed conditions

☐ Beneficiaries using/benefiting

☐ Before/after comparison

5.3 COLLECTING STORIES

Numbers alone aren't enough. You need human stories.

I will collect testimonials from:

☐ At least 3 beneficiaries

☐ At least 1 community leader

☐ At least 1 parent/elder

☐ Team members (what we learned)

Questions to ask beneficiaries:

1. How did this project help you?
2. What has changed in your life because of this?
3. What would you tell other communities about this project?

5.4 DOCUMENTATION PLAN

I will document my project by: *(Check all that apply)*

☐ Taking photos every week (minimum 5 photos per month)

☐ Recording short videos (testimonials, project work)

☐ Keeping a project journal/log

☐ Collecting receipts and records

☐ Writing monthly summaries

☐ Creating a project scrapbook

Who is responsible for documentation?

_____

STEP 6: BUILD SUSTAINABILITY

WHY THIS MATTERS

Many projects die after the competition ends. National Builders create LASTING change.

6.1 WHAT HAPPENS AFTER OCTOBER?

Will your project continue after the National Builders challenge ends?

☐ Yes - here's how

☐ No - it's a one-time intervention

☐ Partially - some parts will continue

If YES, explain your sustainability plan:

_____

_____

_____

_____

6.2 WHO WILL MAINTAIN IT?

After you move on, who will keep this going?

_____

_____

What do they need to maintain it?

_____

_____

How will you train/prepare them?

_____

_____

6.3 ONGOING RESOURCES

What ongoing resources does this project need?

_____

_____

Where will those resources come from?

_____

_____

6.4 SCALING POTENTIAL

Could this project be replicated in other communities?

☐ Yes

☐ No

☐ Maybe

If YES, what would other communities need to copy your model?

_____

_____

_____

What advice would you give them?

_____

_____

_____

SAMPLE PROJECT EXAMPLES

EXAMPLE 1: COMMUNITY LIBRARY PROJECT

Problem: Primary school has 500 students but no library. Children can't practice reading.

Solution: Create a simple community library using donated books and local volunteers.

Action Plan:

- May: Collect 200 books through donation drive
- June: Build simple bookshelves from recycled materials
- July: Train 5 volunteer librarians from the community
- August-September: Open library 3 days per week, track usage
- October: Measure reading improvement in students

Resources:

- Donated books from churches, NGOs, individual homes
- Recycled wood for shelves (from local carpenter)
- Volunteer time from parents and retired teachers
- Classroom space donated by school

Impact Measurement:

- Number of books collected
- Number of children using library weekly
- Reading test scores (before/after)
- Parent testimonials

Sustainability:

- Parent-Teacher Association will manage library
- Monthly book donations from community
- Volunteer rotation schedule created

Estimated Cost: ₦15,000 (for paint, nails, labels, registration system)

EXAMPLE 2: WASTE RECYCLING INITIATIVE

Problem: Market area has no waste management. Garbage piles up, causing health problems and flooding.

Solution: Organize weekly cleanup + recycling system where plastic bottles are collected and sold.

Action Plan:

- May: Map waste hotspots, meet with market leaders
- June: Recruit 10 youth volunteers, get recycling company contact
- July-August: Weekly cleanups every Saturday morning
- September: Create permanent waste collection points
- October: Measure waste reduced, income generated from selling recyclables

Resources:

- Volunteer youth labor (no cost)
- Donated gloves and bags from local businesses
- Partnership with recycling company (buys plastic)
- Market association provides storage space

Impact Measurement:

- Tons of waste collected each month
- Number of volunteers participating
- Money earned from recycling
- Flood incidents reduced (compare to last year)
- Before/after photos of market cleanliness

Sustainability:

- Money from selling recyclables funds ongoing operations
- Youth volunteers rotate, train new people
- Market association incorporates into regular maintenance

Estimated Cost: ₦8,000 (initial supplies, transportation for first month)

EXAMPLE 3: YOUTH SKILLS TRAINING

Problem: Many youth ages 16-25 in community are unemployed with no marketable skills.

Solution: Weekly vocational training in tailoring, phone repair, and hairdressing using local experts.

Action Plan:

- May: Survey youth needs, recruit 3 skilled trainers from community
- June: Enroll 30 youth, begin Saturday training sessions
- July-September: Weekly 2-hour sessions, each person learns one skill
- October: Graduation ceremony, help youth start micro-businesses

Resources:

- Volunteer trainers (experienced tailors, phone technicians, hairdressers)
- Community center space (free)
- Used sewing machines (borrowed/donated)
- Startup kits (small tools) donated by local businesses

Impact Measurement:

- Number of youth trained
- Number who start earning income
- Testimonials about life change
- Skills tests before/after training

Sustainability:

- Graduated students become trainers for next cohort
- Students pay small fee (₦500) if they can afford, creating fund for materials
- Partner businesses hire graduates

Estimated Cost: ₦25,000 (materials, certificates, startup kits for 5 top performers)

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

MISTAKE 1: Planning alone without community input

Why it's bad: Your solution might not match what people actually need.

How to avoid: Interview at least 10 community members before finalizing your plan.

MISTAKE 2: Over-ambitious plans you can't finish

Why it's bad: Better to do one thing excellently than five things poorly.

How to avoid: Be realistic. Can you actually do this in 6 months with your resources?

MISTAKE 3: No backup plan for when things go wrong

Why it's bad: Things WILL go wrong. If you haven't thought ahead, you'll panic and quit.

How to avoid: For every major risk, have a "Plan B" ready.

MISTAKE 4: Forgetting to document as you go

Why it's bad: In October, you'll struggle to remember what you did. You'll have no proof.

How to avoid: Take photos EVERY time you work. Keep a simple journal.

MISTAKE 5: Depending on one person for everything

Why it's bad: If that person gets sick or quits, your whole project collapses.

How to avoid: Distribute responsibilities. Train backups.

MISTAKE 6: Ignoring advice from elders/experts

Why it's bad: They have experience you lack. Their wisdom could save you months of mistakes.

How to avoid: Regularly consult your advisor. Listen with humility.

MISTAKE 7: No plan for what happens after October

Why it's bad: Your project dies the moment the competition ends. No lasting impact.

How to avoid: Build sustainability into your plan from Day 1.

FINAL PLANNING CHECKLIST

Before you start implementing, check that you've completed:

PROBLEM UNDERSTANDING:

☐ I clearly understand the problem I'm solving

☐ I know the root causes, not just symptoms

☐ I've interviewed at least 10 people affected by this problem

☐ I have evidence (photos, numbers) showing the problem exists

☐ I've written a clear problem statement

SOLUTION DESIGN:

☐ I've brainstormed multiple possible solutions

☐ I've evaluated which solution is most feasible

☐ I can explain step-by-step how my solution will work

☐ I've researched what others have done

☐ I've identified potential risks and have backup plans

ACTION PLAN:

☐ I have a detailed timeline with monthly milestones

☐ I know exactly what I'll do each month

☐ I've assigned responsibilities to team members

☐ I have a regular schedule for working on the project

☐ I have realistic deadlines

RESOURCES:

☐ I've listed all materials I need

☐ I know where I'll get each material (buy/borrow/donate/make)

☐ I've identified all volunteers and their roles

☐ I've identified skills I need to learn and how I'll learn them

☐ I have a realistic budget

IMPACT MEASUREMENT:

☐ I know exactly what I'll measure (3-5 metrics)

☐ I'll take "before" measurements/photos in May

☐ I'll take "after" measurements/photos in October

☐ I have a plan to collect testimonials

☐ I'll document my project with photos/videos regularly

SUSTAINABILITY:

☐ I have a plan for what happens after October

☐ I know who will maintain/continue the project

☐ I've identified ongoing resource needs

☐ I've thought about how this could be replicated elsewhere

VALUES INTEGRATION:

☐ I've identified which 3 values will guide my project

☐ I can explain how each value applies to my work

☐ I've signed my Values Commitment in Workbook 1

IF YOU CHECKED ALL BOXES ABOVE, YOU'RE READY TO START!

IF YOU CHECKED FEWER THAN 80%, GO BACK AND COMPLETE THE MISSING SECTIONS.

YOU'RE READY TO BUILD!

Congratulations! You now have a solid project plan.

Remember:

- Your plan is a LIVING DOCUMENT - update it as you learn
- Review this plan at the start of each month
- Share it with your mentor for feedback
- Don't be afraid to adjust when needed

But most importantly: START.

Planning is important, but ACTION is what creates impact.

Your community is waiting for you, National Builder.

Now go make it happen! □□

END OF PROJECT PLANNING GUIDE

For more resources and support, visit:

- **Website:** KidsInspiringNation.org
- **WhatsApp:** [Coordinator Number]
- **Email:** KidsInspiringNation@gmail.com

Next Steps:

1. Complete this planning guide thoroughly
2. Review with your mentor
3. Revise based on feedback
4. START IMPLEMENTING in May!

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